

Healing with Horsetail: Exploring plant kinship through ethnographic art practices

Outline, Supplemental Terms, & Transcript for PowerPoint (Flash) Presentation

November 21, 2025 (American Anthropological Association, AGM)



<https://tinyurl.com/3t7pafkw>

Note: The .ppt utilizes the Pecha Kucha presentation model, featuring 24 slides, each with a 20-second timer, for a total of 8 minutes in length. A small handout will include artwork, poetry, & horsetail remedies.

OUTLINE

- Title
 - Introduction to the problem
 - Inspiration for the research
- Research question and related concepts
 - Plants as kin
 - Contemporary ecological animism
 - Druidry as a spiritual path
 - Visual ways of knowing
- Multispecies Ethnography
 - Cycle 1 & artwork (3 slides)
 - Cycle 2 & artwork (3 slides)
 - Cycle 3 & artwork (4 slides)
- Ecopoetic integration & synthesis (3 slides)
- Findings & conclusion

SUPPLEMENTAL TERMS & REFERENCES:

This shift of consciousness involved shifting to a relational paradigm in the context of **multispecies ethnography** – a more-than-human approach to ethnographic research that challenges the centrality of humans in conventional ethnography, while also emphasizing the partiality and situatedness of our reality (Campenau, 2024, n.p.); other sources (Kirksey & Helmreich, 2010; van Dooren et al., 2016)

Ethography (within the field of Ethnography) provided a mode of responsive encounter that is grounded in *Ethea*, an ethical way of being with others (Rose et al., 2017, p. 122) that emphasizes ethical relations (Van Dooren & Rose, 2016); it provided a way to embody ecological animism.

Ethographic storytelling is about becoming witness—or with-ness—which includes paying attention to *ethos*, the details of others' lives, and cultivating the capacity for response-ability (van Dooren & Bird, 2016, p. 89; Haraway, 2016).

Bricolage or collage – juxtaposes multiple perspectives (Chilton & Scotti, 2014; Scotti & Chilton, 2019)

Relational paradigm - integration of science, nature, and cultural traditions; contextualized as subjective experience; interspecies relations (Viveiros de Castro, 2017; de la Cadena, 2015; de la Cadena & Blaser, 2018)

Interspecies subjectivity – accessing liminal realms, the in-between space of relationships (Scotti & Archer, 2016); relational place: intimacy, empathy, and self-reflection (Finlay & Evans, 2009)

Reflexivity – recursive integration, researcher positionality & responsibility for situatedness (Berger, 2015)

Embodied reciprocal relationships - cultivating “arts of attentiveness” (van Dooren et al., 2016); active listening and noticing when encountering other species; embodiment, bodyfulness, attentive engagement (Caldwell, 2018)

Embodied writing: “relating human experience from the inside out,” an enlivened sense of presence in and of the world (Anderson, 2001)

Kinship, kincentric ecology and kincentric awareness are terms coined by Indigenous scholars to translate these concepts into the English language (Martinez & Hall, 2008; Salmón, 2000; as cited in LeClair, 2021).

Animism – defn: “a particular sensibility and way of relating to various beings in the world. It involves attributing sentience to other beings that may include persons, animals, plants, spirits, the environment, or even items of technology” (Cambridge Encyclopedia of Anthropology, Swancutt, 2019)

Indigenous Animism – a way of life, belief: everything is interrelated; Indigenous animisms arise among people who “cultivate a relationship with the land that reflects thousands of years of cohabitation” (Ojalehto, 2020, p. 52)

Contemporary Ecological Animism – is simply defined as a “responsive relatedness” (Bird-David, 1999); Val Plumwood (2009) defines **philosophical animism** as a path, a way of life, a mode of encounter, which involves ethical relationships, responsive engagement, thereby expanding concepts of communication, exchange, and agency.

The Book of Trees (Lima, 2014) – shows progression of visual symbols associated with trees; symbols became more abstract over time: figurative, vertical, horizontal, multidirectional, radial, rectangular maps, Voronoi maps, circular maps, and sunbursts... follow a linear pattern of growth and production, providing structured patterns to create order and show direct connections

Rhizomatic thinking contrasted with tree thinking (Deleuze & Guattari, 1987) – decentralized connections, not based on hierarchy, opening up fixed concepts to “lines of flight” or the tendency toward change; non-linear growth, networked, a way of mapping an emergent experience that requires new ways of seeing that may be hidden... providing a complex system for sharing knowledge in symbiotic relationships.

TRANSCRIPT (LONG VERSION—abridged for FLASH presentation):

SLIDE 1: Hello, my name is Sandra Christensen (pronouns: she/they). My doctoral research (CIIS, 2025) was titled “Healing with Horsetail: Exploring plant kinship through ethnographic art practices.”

I would like to acknowledge the land where my field research was conducted on the territories of the Dididaht & Nitinaht Nations (Sombrio Beach/ Juan de Fuca Marine Park), a colonized area known as Vancouver Island in the Pacific Northwest (of Canada).

SLIDE 2: I am an adoptee and third-generation settler of mixed European heritage. I am committed to reframing my responsibilities to the land by asking: How can we address harmful human practices due to the instrumental use of plants as resources?

In response to multiple crises of ecological devastation, resource extraction, and consumerism fueled by global economic and corporate dominance, my research focus was on ancient forest communities as places for deep social and ecological healing.

SLIDE 3: While supporting the work of Quw’utsun Elder, Della Rice Sylvester (more than 500 hours in her home, 2017-2018) I deepened my sense of plants as spiritual beings. After horsetail shared a song with me, while gathering medicine for Della, I was able to sustain a plant’s perspective. Deep cultural humility also arose as I sat with discomfort to reconcile my colonial worldview with an Indigenous one.

My inspiration for engaging with embodied art practices came in 2018-2019, while in a home care exchange with settler artist-activist Marion Cumming [1936-2022]. Set in a peaceful sanctuary, deep reflection through art yielded my first collage based on a forest meditation.

SLIDE 4: Informed by this experience, I asked: **What shift of consciousness happens when we acknowledge plants in general—and horsetail in particular—as kin?**

My inquiry emphasized a vegetal, kinship perspective that evolved through a transformative and experiential inquiry process that was slow, emergent, recursive, & rhizomatic.

SLIDE 5: Ethographic art practices deepened a connection to the land, allowing for a more complex and sacred expression of plant relationships. They reflected the embodied engagement between horsetail plants and me, as a researcher, which was conceptualized through interspecies subjectivity, reflexivity, and embodied reciprocal relationships.

SLIDE 6: Indigenous eco-centrism (Johnston, 2022) embeds animist and kincentric beliefs within a traditional lifestyle. For a settler like me, this provided a reminder to not just be critical of the dominant colonial system but also to build a sense of responsibility to raise awareness about the value of ancient forest ecosystems, with plants as autonomous, intelligent beings with agency.

SLIDE 7: As a researcher, I moved from eco-centrism to kin-centrism by engaging in contemporary ecological animism, relating to plants as kin, exploring Druidry as ancestral lineage, and utilizing visual ways of knowing. I witnessed the intelligence of plants that were aware of kin and participated in social networks, demonstrating adaptability through corrective and innovative responses to the environment.

SLIDE 8: As an adoptee and third-generation settler and colonizer, my identity has been uprooted, fragmented, disjointed, and rhizomatic. While my relationship with horsetail deepened, I acknowledged that I lacked deep-rooted cultural traditions to fully engage in Indigenous

animism. Instead, I explored my Indigenous roots in Celtic wisdom and Druidic traditions, which resonated deeply with my animist, nature-centric worldview.

SLIDE 9: In Druidry, trees are used to represent an alphabet, illustrating how language evolved as a relationship with and expression of the land. Many of the images here show a progression of visual symbols associated with trees, which were used to provide a structure for representing linear patterns of knowledge. In contrast, rhizomatic thinking provided a way of mapping an emergent experience requiring nonlinear ways of seeing symbiotic relationships that may be hidden.

SLIDE 10: My research involved three cycles of data gathering between Spring 2022 and Summer 2023 as part of an emergent process. Multispecies ethnography provided a framework to link art practices, narratives, and theory, while allowing time for reflection and integration through a forest (or field) journal, which included internal dialogue and observations with multiple ways of knowing and perceiving (embodied, sensory, emotional, psychological, intellectual).

SLIDE 11: **CYCLE 1** - In the first cycle, I explored several locations in search of horsetail, and one trip to find horsetail in an ancient forest led to a deep healing response to the sudden and tragic loss of a friend and therapist who accidentally drowned. Horsetail connected me with this new, recently departed “ancestor” (a ghost perhaps?) who communicated with me from another dimension. Cyclical stages of growth and development inspired the first major theme, with death and decay serving as nourishment for the next cycle of growth.

SLIDE 12: As I sat with horsetail plants over several weeks, I began to notice the way specific plants moved and interacted with their environment. Drawing became a way of knowing, and using colored charcoal led to reflections on the connection between fossilized plant

remains and the large deposits of coal found in this area. Although many used poisons to kill horsetail, I imagined all the ways humans have been transforming fossilized remains—the bones of plantcestors—into oil, gas, and plastic.

SLIDE 13: In Cycle 1, I began by creating digital collages from my photographs, providing succinct impressions of each site, with a map and close-up images to emphasize the abundance of horsetail.

The waterfall collage was particularly meaningful, as I wanted to transmit the profound healing experience conducted by horsetail through the element of water. Images in multiple scales illustrate how horsetail and skunk cabbage became “larger than life” when dominating my conscious awareness. It was later that evening, still pulsing with the spirit of horsetail, that I connected with my friend who had passed over to another dimension.

SLIDE 14: **CYCLE 2**: After incorporating seasonal rhythms into my research process, the thematic focus in Cycle 2 was on the deep shifts to my concept of time, enriched by Joanna Macy’s nonlinear concept of deep time (the integration of past-present, and future), aligning with Michael Marder’s treatise on “plant time.” This collage illustrates deep time in the evolutionary relationship between humans and horsetail, with humans appearing in a thin top layer.

SLIDE 15: In my art practice, I explored Gemma Anderson’s dynamic drawing method inspired by von Goethe’s. In one experiment, I explored imaginal realms by splattering ink on a page and allowing a subject and image to emerge. This led to a deeper exploration of organic forms contained in a booklet.

SLIDE 16: In Cycle 2, I made many sound recordings next to horsetail plants. This artwork was inspired by sitting in the forest and imagining

what horsetail could hear. Listening *with* horsetail was about tuning into other life forms, including mosses, ferns, lichens, trees, insects, birds, and animals. During the creative process, I became aware of deer spirit guiding me and providing another reminder for “listening with.”

SLIDE 17: CYCLE 3: In Cycle 3, I spent two weeks at Sombrio gathering data. I also performed a Druid self-guided initiation ritual, which inspired the next theme represented by the Druid symbol of “AWEN.” I felt a strong, energetic force at the waterfall site; here, the three strands of energy represent this meeting place of land, sea, and sky—and a dissolving of linear time.

SLIDE 18: Hampered by torrential rains, initial sketches of horsetail plants done inside the camper van contrasted with plants sketched live at the Ditch site, embedded in the forest. At the waterfall site, where I enacted my Druid initiation ceremony, the feeling of AWEN was very powerful, as the land, sea, and sky continually morphed and changed color.

SLIDE 19: In “Plantcestral Memories,” images emerged while listening to soundscapes and imagining how the first vascular plants moved from water to land. During art classes, I began with splatters of blue ink to explore horsetail’s connection with water. “Pacific Eel Bed” retains a sense of fluidity and motion, while “Waterways with Horsetail” emphasizes how ki regulates flow in underground rhizomatic networks.

SLIDE 20: My art style was significantly transformed by listening to soundscapes as part of the creative process. In “Listening with Horsetail,” the recordings were taken in the forest, high above the beach; the vibrations of sound can be felt viscerally in this artwork. In the process, I experienced synesthesia, in which sounds were perceived as colors. (**See my website.*)

SLIDE 21: Two community-based workshops provided a fertile space for synthesizing what I gleaned from horsetail. As shown, “Mapping my writing ecosystems” (CWS & Women’s Spirituality, “Writing in relationship(s): Mapping our writing ecosystems” with Amanda & Amie on April 5th & 19th, 2024) was accompanied by a narrative to explore the connections between my embodied writing process, in conversation with horsetail, following the seasonal rhythms of the land.

SLIDE 22: As part of my integration/synthesis process, I wrote two poems created during the workshop series: “Re-Storying our Relations with the Natural World” (Sierra Club in Fall 2023, with facilitator Andrea Vela Alarcón). The first poem “to horsetail” extends Robin Kimmerer’s (2013) concepts about the grammar of animacy by changing a noun to a verb: What is a horsetail way of being in the world? (*See the handout “Ode to Horsetail” on my website.)

SLIDE 23: The second poem emerged from an invitation to create propositions inspired by Yoko Ono’s “Touch Poems” which were a tribute to the art of Nam June Paik (1960s), who stated that “it has to do with communication on a different dimension.” You are invited to take a moment to consider my proposition while listening to a watery soundscape from a Horsetail community living in the PNW.

SLIDE 24: Plants are interdependent ecological beings. Embedded within the widest understanding of multiple interconnected selves. Ethnographic art practices offer a way of integrating embodied encounters with plant kin by opening the senses, actively listening, and navigating an ecological self, which can support the healing needed for radical transformation (Jeanine Canty, 2014).